

Appendix

Appendix A describes the construction and characteristics of the Mandarin proverb subset used in this study. Appendix B reports the translated English prompts used for the two evaluation tasks with one example of Task 1. Appendix C presents the human evaluation guideline, including the four rating dimensions and their 1–5 Likert scoring scales. Appendix D reports bootstrap confidence intervals for the human evaluation results.

A Dataset Construction

The Mandarin dataset used in this study is a subset of the WISDOM dataset. The original dataset preserves each proverb in its original linguistic form, separates literal wording from pragmatic meaning, provides explanations in both the original language and English, assigns semantic categories, and links proverbs to English equivalents when a true meaning-based correspondence is available.

The Mandarin Chinese subset contains 1,152 proverbs. These proverbs are primarily associated with social, military, and political themes and were extracted from a published collection of Chinese proverbs. The subset includes expressions that draw on history, classical literature, philosophical traditions, and culturally conventionalized forms of social reasoning.

For the present study, each Mandarin proverb entry was normalized into a structured format containing a unique proverb ID, the Mandarin proverb, a Mandarin reference explanation, an English reference explanation, and a semantic category. The resulting dataset was then used to construct two evaluation tasks: situation-to-proverb selection and bilingual proverb explanation. Three entries were reserved as fixed few-shot demonstration examples and excluded from model evaluation. The remaining 1,149 proverbs formed the expected evaluation set for both tasks.

The dataset construction and annotation process involved native-speaker quality check and manual evaluation in the original dataset. In this study, we further inspected the Mandarin subset during task construction to ensure that the entries were properly formatted and suitable for model evaluation.

B Prompts

The prompts used in the experiments were written in Simplified Chinese. For readability, listing 1, listing 2, and listing 3 are English translations.

C Human Evaluation Guideline

Thank you for participating in the evaluation task. The goal of this annotation task is to assess the quality of LLM-generated bilingual explanations of Mandarin proverbs. Each item contains a Mandarin proverb, reference explanations in Mandarin and English, and model-generated explanations in Mandarin and English. Please evaluate each model output carefully and consistently according to the criteria below.

General Instructions: *You will evaluate each model-generated explanation along four dimensions: semantic correctness, cultural faithfulness, clarity, and learner usefulness. Each dimension should be rated on a 5-point Likert scale, where 1 indicates the lowest quality and 5 indicates the highest quality. Please focus on whether the explanation captures the proverb’s core meaning, preserves its cultural and pragmatic implications, is clearly expressed, and would be useful for Chinese language learners or cross-cultural understanding.*

Semantic Correctness: *Evaluate whether the model explanation accurately expresses the core meaning of the proverb. The explanation should correctly capture what the proverb means, rather than merely paraphrasing its literal wording.*

- 5 = Completely accurate.
- 4 = Mostly accurate, with only minor omissions.
- 3 = Generally related, but incomplete.
- 2 = Partly incorrect.
- 1 = Clearly incorrect or seriously misunderstands the proverb.

Cultural Faithfulness: *Evaluate whether the explanation preserves the proverb’s cultural meaning, metaphorical implication, tone, and appropriate usage context. This includes whether the model recognizes culturally conventionalized meanings, historical or literary allusions, and pragmatic implications when relevant.*

- 5 = Very well preserves the cultural and metaphorical meaning.
- 4 = Mostly preserves the cultural and metaphorical meaning.

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1 You are an expert in the semantics and practical use of Chinese proverbs.
2
3 Task: Read the situation and select the proverb that best matches its meaning
   from the four candidate proverbs.
4
5 Requirements:
6 1. Choose exactly one answer from the candidate proverbs.
7 2. The value of "answer" must exactly match one of the candidate proverbs,
   including punctuation and wording.
8 3. Do not explain the reason and do not output any analysis.
9 4. Output exactly one JSON object only. Do not output Markdown, code blocks, or
   additional text.
10 5. The JSON object must follow this format: {"answer":"..."}
11
12 [For the few-shot setting only]
13 Refer to the examples before answering the final item.
14 Examples:
15 {examples}
16
17 Now answer:
18 Situation: {situation}
19
20 Candidate proverbs:
21 {candidates}

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Listing 1: Task 1 prompt template: situation-to-proverb selection. Text in square brackets marks blocks included only in the few-shot condition.

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1 You are an expert in Chinese proverbs, idiomatic allusions, and cross-lingual
   explanation.
2
3 Task: Explain the meaning of the given Chinese proverb, and provide both a
   Chinese explanation and an English explanation.
4
5 Requirements:
6 1. The Chinese explanation should describe the proverb's core meaning, applicable
   context, and implied attitude.
7 2. The English explanation should accurately express the Chinese meaning and
   should not be a word-for-word literal translation.
8 3. Do not invent sources, historical figures, or historical background.
9 4. Output exactly one JSON object only. Do not output Markdown, code blocks, or
   additional text.
10 5. The JSON object must follow this format: {"zh":"...","en":"..."}
11
12 [For the few-shot setting only]
13 Examples:
14 {examples}
15
16 Now answer:
17 Proverb: {proverb}

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Listing 2: Task 2 prompt template: bilingual proverb explanation. Text in square brackets marks blocks included only in the few-shot condition.

- 3 = Provides some explanation, but the cultural or contextual meaning is weak.
- 2 = Cultural meaning is largely missing or partly misinterpreted.
- 1 = Completely fails to capture the cultural meaning or seriously misinterprets it.

Clarity: Evaluate whether the explanation is clear, fluent, and easy to understand. A clear explanation should be readable and coherent, but it should also avoid unnecessary redundancy or overly vague wording.

- 5 = Very clear.

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1 Situation: Mr. Wang has warmly helped his neighbors for many years, lending a
  hand whenever anyone was in difficulty. Now that he is hospitalized, the
  neighbors take turns bringing him meals and visiting him, filling the ward
  with care and support. Lying in bed, he feels that his past kindness was not
  in vain.
2
3 Candidate proverbs:
4 1. A ten-foot lampstand lights up others but never itself
5 2. Birds fly back to their native land; a dying fox turns its head toward its
  home hill
6 3. What we eat is salt and rice; what we live by is human feeling and reason
7 4. As one sows, so shall one reap

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Listing 3: Situation-to-proverb selection example.

- 4 = *Clear.*
- 3 = *Understandable, but the expression is redundant or slightly unclear.*
- 2 = *Unclear or awkward.*
- 1 = *Difficult to understand.*

Learner Usefulness: Evaluate whether the explanation would be useful for Chinese language learners or for cross-cultural understanding. A useful explanation should help learners understand the general meaning of the proverb, and when and why it may be used.

- 5 = *Very useful for learning, teaching, or cross-cultural understanding.*
- 4 = *Useful.*
- 3 = *Moderately useful.*
- 2 = *Of limited usefulness.*
- 1 = *Not useful or potentially misleading.*

D Confidence Intervals for Human Evaluation

Table 1 reports nonparametric bootstrap 95% confidence intervals for the human evaluation means. Resampling was conducted over the 20 output-level scores in each model-setting condition after averaging the two annotators' ratings for each output.

Model	Setting	Semantic Correctness	Cultural Faithfulness	Clarity	Learner Usefulness	Overall
Qwen-2.5-7B	Zero-shot	[2.95, 4.13]	[2.43, 3.50]	[3.65, 4.38]	[2.80, 3.73]	[2.99, 3.93]
Llama-3.1-8B	Zero-shot	[2.15, 3.25]	[1.93, 2.85]	[3.03, 3.70]	[2.25, 3.13]	[2.35, 3.21]
DeepSeek-V4-Flash	Zero-shot	[4.68, 4.95]	[4.05, 4.53]	[4.50, 4.85]	[4.03, 4.30]	[4.36, 4.62]
GPT-5.4	Zero-shot	[4.43, 4.85]	[3.90, 4.35]	[3.88, 4.30]	[3.70, 4.08]	[4.04, 4.34]
Qwen-2.5-7B	Few-shot	[3.60, 4.63]	[3.30, 4.20]	[4.45, 4.83]	[3.50, 4.25]	[3.73, 4.45]
Llama-3.1-8B	Few-shot	[2.70, 3.80]	[2.38, 3.38]	[3.40, 4.05]	[2.53, 3.43]	[2.76, 3.64]
DeepSeek-V4-Flash	Few-shot	[4.43, 4.90]	[3.95, 4.43]	[4.63, 4.88]	[3.85, 4.33]	[4.24, 4.61]
GPT-5.4	Few-shot	[3.70, 4.60]	[3.40, 4.13]	[3.83, 4.20]	[3.08, 3.78]	[3.57, 4.12]

Table 1: Bootstrap 95% confidence intervals for Task 2 human evaluation means (10,000 resamples at the output level; $n = 20$ per model–setting condition).